

VERSION 1.0 - PRODUCTION CANDIDATE

Urdu Workbook

اردو

Writing and pronunciation foundations, core grammar, 1,000 audited vocabulary entries, and 1,000 curated bilingual practice sentences with handwriting and retrieval space.

Foundations

Natural, idiomatic learner language takes priority over artificial uniqueness. Genuine homographs are retained when their learner meaning and grammatical role differ. A source-backed pronunciation key is taught in Foundations; sentence drills then use normal target-language spelling rather than inconsistent ad-hoc romanization.

Foundations

Target register: standard Urdu in Nastaliq. These pages orient deliberate practice; the vocabulary and sentence sections provide the bulk of retrieval work.

Script / alphabet reference

ا ب پ ت ٹ ث ج چ ح خ د ڈ ذ ر ز س ش ص ض ط ظ ع غ ف ق ک گ
ل م ن ں و ہ ع ی ے

Use this as a compact reference, then practice connected words rather than isolated shapes alone.

Numbers 0-10

۱۰ ۹ ۸ ۷ ۶ ۵ ۴ ۳ ۲ ۱ ۰
صفر ۰ ایک ۱ دو ۲ تین ۳ چار ۴ پانچ ۵ چھ ۶ سات ۷ آٹھ ۸ نو ۹ دس ۱۰

Writing system

Urdu is written from right to left in a Perso-Arabic script, commonly in Nastaliq. Connected words, vertical stacking, and baseline flow matter more than copying isolated glyphs indefinitely.

Sounds and spelling

Urdu adds letters and conventions for sounds not represented the same way in Arabic or Persian, including retroflex and aspirated consonants. Short vowels are often unmarked.

Word order

Neutral Urdu word order is usually subject-object-verb. Postpositions follow noun phrases, so whole chunks are safer than word-for-word English mapping.

Gender and agreement

Nouns have grammatical gender. Adjectives and verbs can change for gender and number, and agreement also interacts with tense/aspect and postpositions.

Respect and pronouns

آپ is the normal respectful/formal second-person form and takes plural-style agreement. تم is familiar; تو is highly intimate or potentially rude outside close contexts.

Ergativity

In many perfective transitive clauses, نے marks the agent and verb agreement may follow the object instead. Treat this as a recurring pattern rather than forcing English subject agreement onto Urdu.

Handwriting warm-up

Copy five useful words from today's lesson, then write them again from memory.

Pronunciation quick-start

Broad standard Urdu pronunciation in Nastaliq. The guide prioritizes contrasts that the script can obscure for beginners, especially dental/retroflex place, aspiration, vowel length/quality, and nasalization.

Notation: slashes / / show broad IPA phonemes or practical reference targets. They are more precise than English respellings but still do not encode every accent or connected-speech detail.

Dental versus retroflex

ت /t̪/ • د /d̪/ versus ط /t̚/ • ڈ /d̚/ • ڑ /ɖ̪/

Keep tongue placement distinct: dental stops contact the teeth; retroflex sounds use a retracted or curled tongue-tip gesture.

Aspiration

پ /p/ versus پھ /pʰ/ • ک /k/ versus کھ /kʰ/

Aspiration is contrastive. In aspirated digraphs, do-chashmi he ه marks the aspirated series; do not pronounce it as a separate extra syllable.

Short and long vowels

short-vowel series versus long-vowel series

Vowel length and quality can distinguish words. Short vowels are often not written, while long vowels are more often represented with ا، و، ی/ے and related orthographic patterns.

Nasalization

word-final ں = nūn ghunnah

Word-final ں commonly marks nasalization of the preceding vowel rather than a full oral /n/. Medial nasalization uses different orthographic conventions and must be read in context.

و versus ه

ه /h/ or orthographic element • ه aspiration marker

Gol he و and do-chashmi he ه have different roles. The latter normally participates in aspirated consonant digraphs.

Perso-Arabic loan consonants

ق /q/ · خ /x/ · غ /ɣ/ · ف /f/ · ث /ʒ/

Careful standard speech can distinguish these sounds, while some speakers merge particular loan phonemes with more common sounds. Recognize both the careful target and normal speaker variation.

و and ی

و may be consonantal /ʊ~w/ or part of a vowel spelling;

ی may be /j/ or part of a vowel spelling

These letters are multifunctional, so their pronunciation must be interpreted from the word rather than assigned one fixed sound.

Stress

not marked in ordinary spelling

Urdu stress is not written directly and depends on phonological structure. For beginners, preserve consonant place, aspiration, vowel contrasts, and nasalization first, then refine stress with reliable native audio.

Three-step pronunciation routine

1. Before reading, mark any retroflex letter, aspirated digraph, long-vowel spelling, or nūn ghunnah.
2. Say dental/retroflex and aspirated/unaspirated pairs deliberately enough that the contrast survives when you speed up.
3. Because ordinary Urdu omits many short-vowel cues, confirm unfamiliar words before drilling them repeatedly instead of guessing from consonantal spelling alone.

Sentence drills intentionally stay in normal target-language spelling: the pronunciation key supports decoding without creating dependence on ad-hoc romanization.

Sources, licensing, and QA scope

Vocabulary: drawn from this repository's canonical audited top-1,000 deck for the language. Repository source and audit records remain the source of truth.

Sentence provenance: Arabic and French sentence pairs originate from the ManyThings bilingual exports of the Tatoeba Project and retain their supplied sentence-level attribution under CC BY 2.0 France. Urdu v1.0 uses UALIS Publishing original controlled learner sentences; those rows carry UALIS source provenance and are not represented as third-party Tatoeba quotations.

Editorial curation: the sentence corpus is rendered from the versioned v1.0 row-decision ledger for each language. KEEP rows retain the audited pair exactly; approved corrections retain the row's original source provenance and are marked as editorial adaptations.

Pronunciation foundations: broad-IPA and articulatory guidance was cross-checked against Karin C. Ryding, *A Reference Grammar of Modern Standard Arabic*; Bernard Tranel, *The Sounds of French*; Saleem et al., *Urdu Consonantal and Vocalic Sounds*; and the Omniglot Urdu-script reference. These are broad learner reference targets, not a claim of one accent-free realization.

Quality scope: release gates check canonical dataset integrity, exact row-decision alignment, duplicate handling, source provenance, applicable external-license attribution, PDF structure, font support, and renderability. These controls materially reduce release risk but do not substitute for independent native-speaker certification; no absolute error-free claim is made.